In essence, the use of this weapon can only be considered as a means to “blind” and take the other side by surprise and to interfere with its capability to respond to a nuclear attack. Moreover, once this weapon is created the process of improving it will begin, giving it ever increasing combat characteristics. Such is the law of the development of any weapons. How, Mr. President, should the Soviet Union respond in this situation? I would like to repeat what I said in Geneva. The USSR simply cannot and will not accept the situation of the U.S. realization of the SDI program and then to reduce nuclear weapons. To provide for its security, come what may, we will be forced to develop and perfect strategic nuclear forces to increase their ability to neutralize the American “space shield.” At the same time, we would be forced to develop our own space weapons, including those for national ballistic missile defense. Apparently the U.S., for its part, would adopt other kinds of measures. As a result, we would not be able to break out of this vicious circle, and in the final analysis, from the whirlpool of the ever spiraling arms race. The end results of such action inimical to our people and all of mankind would be unspeakable.

I am convinced that the only rational way is not to do this. From all points of view, the right path for our countries is to prevent an arms race in space and halt it on earth. Moreover, it is necessary to negotiate under equal and mutually acceptable conditions.

In addition to objecting to the SDI program, Gorbachev disputed my view that the Soviets’ huge stockpile of long-range land-based missiles gave them superiority in the nuclear race; American Trident submarine-launched missiles, he said, allowed us to launch a surprise attack on the Soviets with much less warning time than their land-based missiles, and therefore they provided a threat to the